

Veterans e-Post Hub

Web Development Project Description Report

Sponsor: Becky Buri

Whitman County Veteran Services



15-FA25-SP26-WCVS-WEB

Logan Cribbs
Chhi Ly

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I. Introduction

Supporting those who have served is a responsibility that extends beyond words of gratitude. Today, many veterans face significant challenges when transitioning to civilian life — from finding reliable resources and community support to pursuing meaningful career opportunities. This project builds upon the efforts of previous developers who shared the vision of empowering veterans through technology. Our goal is to expand and enhance this web platform by introducing new features and improving existing ones, ensuring it remains an accessible, intuitive, and user-friendly digital space for veterans.

Our Veteran Service Officer, Becky Buri, is deeply committed to supporting those who have served, and we share that commitment through this project. Serving those who have served our country is at the heart of our mission. While the website is already operational and fully functional, our goal is to take it to the next level — simplifying its layout and format, removing redundancies, and adding new features that create a streamlined, seamless experience for the intended audience.

II. Background and Related Work

The Whitman County Veterans Services (WCVS) e-Post project is located within the domain of community resource web development, with an emphasis on creating accessible and organized resources for veterans. The scope of our project centers on streamlining the existing e-Post so that users can effectively find the information and resources needed for events and programs offered to community veterans. The current webpage contains all the required functionality, but the page design creates challenges in its usability, which is what we are aiming to correct. There are various design flaws, such as redundant or unwanted text, a confusing landing page, event tiles that are not uniform, etc. By addressing these issues, we aim to create a user-friendly veterans resource page that prioritizes important or new information, consolidates and categorizes resources, and minimizes page clutter, making it easier to navigate. Next, we looked into the best front/back-end practices from other government resource sites in order to give us insight into how to progress with the project.

To inform our design choices, we examined various public service websites. We used the Veterans Affairs platform [1] and its design structure as a model for front-end usability. The website demonstrated consistent navigation, a clear information hierarchy, and a grid layout that helps to separate large amounts of information. All of the subpages share layouts, creating uniformity throughout their services. Many of these features align with the goal of our project; they create clear visuals of where to find information and how to navigate the page. By incorporating these layout choices, we hope to be able to provide a large amount of information without overwhelming users. These insights helped to guide our decisions to implement categorized tabs and uniform tiles that make the page content easier to look over and interact with.

For the backend, instead of using a plugin-heavy content management system (CMS) like WordPress, the site is built with Next.js for the framework, Prisma as the database tool [2], and SQLite as the database to store all required information. This setup is easy to maintain and simple for future developers to update the site or add features. Using this approach, we have control over how the site works, and it aids in improving performance by avoiding common issues with a more complex system. The backend information gathered was more for our own understanding of the project after taking over its development. For the client's needs, most of our work will involve front-end changes that we will incorporate while trying not to alter the existing backend codebase.

Our work applies the best practices we have gathered from large-scale webpages to meet the specific needs of a smaller, local organization. Unlike other large national websites, the WCVS e-Post will focus on keeping the layout simple while prioritizing the most useful information for Whitman County veterans.

To complete this project, our team will need to continue improving our frontend skills with HTML, CSS, and JavaScript. Additionally, we will need to improve our understanding of the database design using Prisma and SQLite. Lastly, we will need to learn some new tools, such as Vercel, for the deployment of the page. By combining these skills with the prior skills of the team and the research gathered from exploring sites like VA.gov, we will be able to revamp the WCVS e-Post so that it is organized, structured, and easy to navigate.

III. Project Overview

This project represents the continued development of a web platform designed to provide veterans with a centralized and accessible space for resources, community connections, and opportunities for personal and professional growth. Veterans often face significant challenges when transitioning to civilian life, including navigating support services, securing employment opportunities, and finding a sense of belonging within their communities. Guided by the vision of Becky Buri, this platform aims to address these challenges by offering a user-friendly and intuitive space where veterans and their families can easily access information, connect with local organizations, and stay informed about events and initiatives that matter to them.

The scope of this project includes maintaining the existing functionality of the website while introducing targeted enhancements to improve its usability, design, and overall impact. Planned improvements include simplifying the layout and format, reducing redundancies, addressing previously identified issues, and adding new features such as enhanced event listings, comprehensive resource directories, and streamlined navigation. These upgrades are intended to create a smooth, efficient, and engaging user experience that accommodates veterans of all technical backgrounds.

This will include improving how administrators create and update events, prioritize information, and manage user inquiries. By creating a simpler content management structure, future administrators will be able to quickly familiarize themselves with the page. This will help ensure that the webpage will continue serving the community for years to come.

A smoother layout and better navigation tools will help users to quickly find the needed information on events and resources, which will promote future use of the webpage. Improved management tools will keep the content relevant and up to date, which is crucial to ensure that community veterans are getting the most accurate information regarding opportunities, services, and announcements. The success of the project will be determined by how efficiently users can navigate the webpage, how often they return, and how effectively it can be updated and maintained.

Our focus on these issues and our plan to improve them ensure that the changes we make align with the actual needs of veterans and the long-term goals of the organization. Following the mission of Whitman County Veterans Services, we aim to deliver a refined, accessible, and sustainable webpage that helps Whitman County veterans connect with their community and the opportunities available to them.

These improvements are being guided by feedback from Veteran Service Officer, Becky Buri, project mentor, Dr. Parteek Kumar, and the previous web developers who have interacted and worked closely with the platform. Their input is crucial to gaining requirements, technical information, and ensuring that we all have a shared vision for the completion of the project.

IV. Client and Stakeholder Identification and Preferences

Client Identification

The primary client for this project is the Veteran Service Office, Becky Buri, who acts as the representative for the veteran community we aim to serve. The Veteran Service Officer's role is to ensure that the platform provides accurate information, accessible resources, and an interface that is easy for veterans to navigate. Their involvement helps guide the direction of the project, ensuring that every improvement and added feature supports the mission of serving those who served.

Stakeholder Identification

Beyond the client, several key stakeholder groups influence and benefit from the platform. Veterans and their families remain the core users, relying on the website to access resources, connect with the Whitman community, and explore local opportunities for support and growth. Their needs guide many of the design and functionality decisions made throughout this project to ensure the platform remains relevant and useful.

Our mentor, Dr. Parteek Kumar, also plays a vital role by providing technological guidance, sharing documentation from previous development efforts, and offering valuable insights from their industry experience on how best to manage and scale the product. Their expertise has been instrumental in shaping our approach and ensuring we adhere to best practices.

The development team, we are another critical stakeholder, taking ownership of the design, implementation, and ongoing maintenance of the website's functionality. The team's decisions directly impact the user experience, system reliability, and long-term sustainability of the platform.

Finally, community partners such as employers, educators, and local organizations represent an important stakeholder group. These partners have the potential to contribute opportunities, events, and other initiatives that further support veterans and strengthen the platform's impact within the local community.

Preferences and Expectations

During development, stakeholder feedback highlighted several key preferences that guided the design and functionality of the platform. Ease of use was consistently emphasized, with stakeholders requesting a clean and accessible layout that accommodates users with minimal technical experience. Efficiency was another priority, with a strong preference for presenting information and resources clearly and enabling users to locate content or perform searches with as few steps as possible.

Stakeholders also expressed a desire for a modern, minimalist, and professional appearance that reflects the respect owed to veterans and their service. Functionality was equally important, with clear expectations for reliable event listings, easily viewable images, comprehensive resource directories, and contact forms that operate seamlessly across devices.

By integrating these preferences into our development process and carefully structuring our tasks and objectives, we aim to deliver a platform that fulfills the client's mission, meets stakeholder expectations, and incorporates thoughtful enhancements that reflect our team's unique vision.

V. Glossary

Control Management System - A software tool that allows users to create, edit, and publish content through an easy-to-use interface, without needing to write any code.

Digital Accessibility - ensuring content and technologies are usable by everyone, including people with various disabilities, by removing barriers and promoting equal access to information and services.

Functional requirements - describe what a system (webpage) must do, specifying the features and behaviors a user experiences.

Non-functional requirements - specify how a system (webpage) should operate, focusing on its quality attributes and constraints rather than specific actions.

Web Development - process of creating and maintaining websites and web applications; combining technical skills and creative problem-solving to build functional, interactive digital experiences.

VI. References

[1] U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs, “VA.gov,” *U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs*, 2025. [Online]. Available: <https://www.va.gov>. [Accessed: 8- Sept- 2025].

[2] Prisma, “Prisma Documentation,” *Prisma.io*, 2025. [Online]. Available: <https://www.prisma.io/docs/>. [Accessed: 10- Sept- 2025].

Reference resource: <http://www.ieee.org/documents/ieeecitationref.pdf> (IEEE citation standard)